

The Culture and Economic Impact of Vup

——take Aza and his fans and audiences as an example

● Abstract

This study will explore the culture and economic impact of Vup, especially the Vup in China social media platforms. I will focus on Vup and fans on Bilibili, and I will take Aza and his fans as my study sample. The research will discuss why his fans devote a lot for him and pay so much attention, emotion and money on him, and in order to predict the economic impact and fan culture impact of Vup in the Chinese Internet environment from now to the future. Through the interview and questionnaires methodology, and by analysing the data I collect from the interview and questionnaires, I will draw some conclusions. For example, what is the role of Vup in the hearts of fans on Chinese social media, why fans are willing to invest so much money, time and affection for them, as well as the economic impact and fans culture of Vup. This research contributes to live streaming of Aza, live streaming of Vup on the Chinese Internet and even live streaming of Vup worldwide about economic impact and fans culture effect. Also, as one of the greatest representation of minority culture of ACGN, the vigorous development and economic benefits of Vup seem to be the epitome and reflection of the economic benefits created by minority culture. By provide the minority of people with the specific and niche interests service, it can diversify and stabilize our economic growth.

● Introduction

Vup——as known as VTuber, a branch of ACGN (A: animation, C: comic, G: game, N: novel) culture. Vup are streamers and most of them are from YouTube, Bilibili and Tiktok. Generally, it is termed as VUP in China, and called VTuber in Japan, South Korea, and regions of Europe and America. The two merely differ in name, and there is no essential distinction in other aspects. They usually sing songs, play games, talk with other Vup and chat with their fans when live streaming. Vup are based on anime characters, supported by motion and facial expression tracking software systems to move and speak freely like anime characters. The example I choose is Aza. He is a Vup with five years of live broadcast experience, also, he is representative and typical. He also has a lot of fans and a strong company behind him. so I will choose him as an example for my investigation and research.

Here are some basic background information of my example Aza. He is a Vup on Bilibili and a member of a Japan VTuber company Nijisanji. On the one hand, there are something interesting about his fans culture, he has more than 3 million followers over his social media platforms and more than 13 hundred thousands posts in his tag and there are all his fanart about his personal drawings and discussions. On the other hand, when it comes to his economic impact, on August 2024, more than 10,000 people on Bilibili had become his paid members. All the charges added up to more than 1.5 million yuan. It is a good way to demonstrate his value of business and economic. It can be seen that fans have paid a lot of money, time and emotion for him. They're not even human streamers, and the emotional and financial investment of his fans are hard to get pay back from him, also, Vup are not real human streamers, so there's no way to have much interaction with the fans like real people. Therefore, I will compare the differences between highly invested fans and regular viewers in terms of their psychology, perception of him, and other related aspects.

● Literature Review

Firstly, according to the study by Lee, S. and Lee, J., titled “Ju.T’aime: My Idol, My Streamer - A Case Study on Fandom Experience as Audiences and Creators of a VTuber Concert,” provides a comprehensive analysis of the distinctive characteristics, phenomena, and challenges associated with virtual streamer communities. Through a survey of approximately 1,795 audience members and in-depth interviews with 10 voluntary streamers who also act as content creators, the study reveals how platform types and VTuber roles (such as idols or streamers) significantly influence audience presence and immersion. With its robust methodological approach and thorough analysis, this study serves as a credible and valuable resource for understanding virtual streaming communities within academic discourse.

Secondly, according to Boonchutima, S. and Surakanon, A. This study aims to examine the impact of 2 types of influencers, VTubers and streamers, on the willing and intention of purchasing, Otaku and non-Otaku respondents. This quantitative approach using an online survey was conducted among Thai respondents (about 686 people) to assess the influence of attractiveness and trustworthiness on their intention of purchase induced by VTubers and streamers. This article is highly related to consumption and purchase desire, so I think it is

very useful for me and well worth reading and thinking about.

Then, the rise of virtual technology has created a new influencer model centered on crafted personas and animated avatars, leading to the emergence of a popular and promising industry. This paper introduces the concept of virtual entertainers, identifies three key dimensions—Organizational Support, Self Expression, and Activity—and presents five distinct archetypes based on an analysis of comments and livestreams. By comparing the performances of these archetypes across various success indicators, the study offers insights for understanding and developing effective positioning strategies in the virtual entertainer industry. This article is very long and mainly describes the economic value of VTuber, which is very relevant to my topic. Moreover, it provides a lot of quantitative data, and the reference data and articles are also very reliable, which is very close to today's data.

Lastly, P. Gwillim-Thomas explains that Virtual YouTubers (VTubers) are 2D or 3D character models controlled through facial and motion tracking, broadcast on various internet platforms. This report contains substantial data and surveys across platforms, making it highly credible. However, my focus is specifically on Bilibili streamers, and the Bilibili data in this article is limited. Moreover, the Internet and VTuber landscapes differ significantly between China and other countries, so additional sources are needed for a comprehensive understanding.

In summary, we can see that there have been many studies on the topic about VTuber before. But I found that most of them are about VTuber in Japan or America, while Chinese VTuber is rarely include. China is the industrial power of ACGN culture, because China has a huge population and a large number of young people who like ACGN culture, and China's local VTuber also has a large amount of fans, so China's VTuber market can not be ignored either. Furthermore, I noted that most accessible articles on VTubers primarily focus on technical and macro-level analyses, often examining VTubers themselves rather than the fans who support them. However, there is a notable lack of research dedicated to the fans who engage with and support VTubers in less visible, yet essential, ways. I believe this topic presents a novel and intriguing research opportunity, and I plan to pursue a deeper, more focused investigation into the experiences and motivations of VTuber fans.

- Theoretical Frameworks

According to Schramm's model of communication, the communication process consists of media and the audience, with a relationship of transmission and feedback between the two. As the communicator, the media is connected to a specific source of information and through the reproduction of messages, is linked to the audience as the object of communication. Therefore, although Vup is the only one who can speak in a live streaming and holds the primary control over the topics, the audience is also a crucial participant in this live streaming activity. In the communication process, interaction and feedback between Vup and the audience are essential. However, a significant portion of the audience's thoughts often remain unknown within the live streaming. Thus, understanding the audience's psychology and the culture of fan communities becomes necessary. This can make the live streaming more engaging and interactive, benefiting both the host and the company, while also providing the audience with enhanced emotional value.

● Description Of Analysis Object

In this research, the specific object will focus on 200 fans of Aza, and they will be selected and divided into 2 groups. One group (100 people) is the fans who give Aza financial support (become his paid membership) and engagement deeply into Aza's fans culture. (For example, the fans who painted pictures for him, bought his co-branded products, and even gone to his concerts). I will choose 100 people from the post of Aza's paid member appreciation list. Another group (100 people) is just the normal audiences of him and had never become his paid membership or never took part in the relative activity. I will choose this group of people in the list of Aza's followers but without being his paid membership or never taking part in his related activity.

● Methodology

I will select 100 fans and 100 normal audiences of Aza, ask them to finish the questionnaire to compare their psychology and opinion, after that, I will choose 10 people from fans group and 10 people from normal audiences respectively. I will select 20 individuals from the 200 based on the following criteria: First, responses must be reasonable and effective. Second, responses should have general reference value and representativeness. Third, responses should offer potential for further discussion and interview. Fourth, responses should be distinctly different from others, yet remain reasonable.

The research will dig into and compare different aspects like the psychology of fans and normal audiences, identification and what different kinds of groups think about Aza to understand their perspectives and behaviour about the consumption and devotion for Aza. I will conduct in-depth online interviews with these 20 individuals to gain a more detailed understanding of the differences in their perspectives. I will also analyze their data to reach my conclusions. I will protect the privacy of all interviewees and it doesn't violate any legal or ethical requirements.

- Research Design

Regarding the questionnaire survey, I will group and select different respondents, then systematically compile, categorize, and filter their responses. Similar answers will be merged into one category, and I will calculate the proportion of this category relative to the total number of responses. This will reflect the importance and commonality of each answer.

Additionally, I will compare data between the general audience group and the fan group to analyze the psychological differences between Aza's fans and regular audiences.

Regarding the in-depth interviews, I will selectively screen interviewees based on their questionnaire responses and contact them via WeChat or Bilibili for online meetings. The interviews will be fully recorded, with prior consent. After the interviews, I will organize and analyze the data to further compare the psychological differences between the general audience and the fans.

Timeline:

From 2nd November 2024 to 4th November 2024: selecting, contacting and confirming interviewees.

From 5th November 2024 to 13rd November 2024: distribute questionnaires and organize and analyze data.

From 14th November 2024 to 16th November 2024: identify the interviewees of the in-depth interview.

From 17th November 2024 to 18th November: in-depth interview, collation and analysis of data.

From 19th November 2024 to 20th November 2024: complete the report.

Potential problems and risks: firstly, I may not be able to find suitable or enough interviewees. Secondly, I may not have enough time to collect samples and analyze data. Last one, the questions in my questionnaire may not be completely reasonable, so it cannot give a good feedback of the real situation.

- Conclusion Of Proposal:

I will focus on comparing the ways in which regular viewers and fan communities support Aza, including the intensity and nature of their support, in order to analyze their psychological differences. This will help highlight the distinctions and variations between the audience and fan community in terms of their relationship with Aza. When it comes to the potential result of my potential result, I predict that some fans who devote themselves to Aza a lot may because they regard emotional connection with Aza. Because Aza interact and share his personality makes fans feel like “friend” or “idol” relationship, and to show their appreciation or support, fans may donate. And for another reason, it is about the community identity of fans group. Donating and take part in Aza related activities gives fans a sense of belonging within Aza community. By contributing financially, they feel invested in the Aza growth and success, and they feel like an essential part of the journey.

- Reference

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● Appendix 1 - Questionnaire Outline

1. What is your age and gender?
2. What is the role do you think Aza play in your daily life?
3. How long have you been the audience of fans of Aza?
4. How long do you watch live a month, when do you usually watch it?
5. Have you ever participated in a discussion in the Vup's topic tag? Have you ever participated in any offline activities of Vup? And Why?
6. If there is a product combined with him, will it enhance your desire to buy? And why?
7. Do you support Aza by sending gifts or becoming a member? If so, how much do you pay per month? What motivates you to do so or not to do so?
8. Do you interact with other fans or join fan communities? If so, what draws you to these groups?

● Appendix 2 - In-Depth Interview Brief Outline

1. How would you describe your emotional connection to Aza? Do you think this is related to whether or not you pay to watch?
2. How did you decide whether or not to become a paid viewer of Aza?
3. Do you think paid viewers and regular viewers have different attitudes when interacting with Aza?
4. Do you feel that paid viewers and regular viewers have different experiences when participating in a live stream? If so, what are the differences?/ Do you think Aza will treat regular viewers differently than paying viewers?/ During live streams, do paid viewers get more attention from the VTuber than regular viewers?
5. Do you feel a greater sense of belonging or privilege by being a paid viewer? (To Aza's paid fans member only)
6. What is your opinion on ways to support Aza, such as tipping or becoming a member? (To Aza's paid fans member only)

7. Do you think paid viewers have higher expectations of the Aza content compared to regular viewers? Why?
8. Do you feel that the content or interaction you receive after paying is more valuable? If so, what gives you that impression?
9. When watching Aza, are you more inclined to interact (e.g., via bullet comments, chats, etc.)? Does being a paid viewer influence this?
10. Do you think paid viewers have a different status or influence within the Aza community compared to regular viewers?
11. Do you feel that the sense of participation differs between paid viewers and regular viewers when watching content?
12. What do you think are the most significant psychological or emotional differences between paid viewers and regular viewers?

Instructions: the two appendices outline above are my general ideas. I will adjust the questions and their order flexibly based on the different responses and reactions of the interviewees, but the questionnaire and interview will generally follow the questions outlined above.